TUKARAM MUNDHE

GRILLING THE EATERIES

FDA commissioner Tukaram Mundhe's food-safety crackdown has made him Maharashtra's man of the moment, winning public admiration while drawing scrutiny from courts and industry

By DHAVAL S. KULKARNI



THE ENFORCER Mundhe after a press conference in Mumbai, Aug. 26; below, some of the kitchens found wanting in FDA crackdowns

On the face of it, little seems to have changed at Noor Mohammadi Hotel in Mumbai's Bhendi Bazaar. The white-topped tables are still in place; its signature Nalli Nihari and Chicken Sanju Baba—a dish based on a recipe given by actor Sanjay Dutt—continue to draw committed patrons; and the framed M.F. Husain painting of a rooster still hangs on the wall. But the roughly 1,200 diners who eat here each day will notice the difference on closer inspection: a sharper focus on cleanliness, with staff now wearing gloves and hairnets.

The transformation is the result of a crackdown by the Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA), led by its 51-year-old commissioner, Tukaram Mundhe. The 2005-batch IAS officer has emerged as the new spectre haunting the state's Food Business Operators (FBOs) who flout safety and hygiene norms. By the end of August, around 10,000 FBOs had reportedly been inspected.

Since joining the FDA in May, Mundhe has led a campaign that has taken on everyone from iconic establishments such as Noor Mohammadi, Ayub's, Poornima, K. Rustom & Co. and Parsi Dairy Farm to well-known food operators such as ISKCON's Govinda's and IRCTC's base kitchens; from clubs patronised by the rich and powerful—the Cricket Club of India and Mumbai Cricket Association (MCA)—to global brands such as Domino's Pizza and Pizza Hut. Little wonder, the FDA commissioner has become a viral sensation on social media, the joke being a 'Tukaram Mundhe approval badge' carries more heft for any eatery than a Michelin star.

Mundhe's enforcement has extended even to the canteens at Mantralaya and the Bombay High Court. After the HC questioned whether the FDA had inspected canteens in government and semi-government institutions, its officials visited those on the court premises. Of the three canteens, one was operating without a valid FSSAI (Food Safety and Standards Authority of India) licence and was ordered to stop operations, while the other two were issued improvement notices. The FDA has also banned the sale of junk food such as vada paav and energy drinks in school canteens and within a 50-metre radius of schools, as well as the sale of 'analogue' paneer, a cheaper substitute made from milk solids, vegetable fats and other low-cost ingredients.

The crackdown has extended beyond eateries and food products, too. The FDA has served notices to actors Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff over their appearance in alleged surrogate advertisements for a pan masala brand.

Despite shaking up the food industry, Mundhe says he considers the crackdown "nothing great" but simply "routine work". He believes that while regulators should impose the writ of law, citizens, too, need to be vigilant about what they buy and consume. "This is an issue that is related to all, from the young to the aged," says Mundhe. Stressing that the agency is acting in a "fair and transparent" manner, he says he is working without a vested interest. "My only vested interest is to serve the people of Maharashtra." He also rejects the charge that the FDA has acted in a high-handed manner, pointing to its powers under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006. "The system is so broken," says an official, "that an officer who is just doing his duty is hailed as a hero."